

Memorandum

To: Dr. Ernest Gibson, Dr. Derek Ross, Dr. Susan Youngblood
From: Jolisa Brewster
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Subject: Technical Editing Analysis
Keywords: editing, collaboration, design, publication, theories, audience.

Purpose

In Dr. Ross's graduate-level Technical Editing course, my colleagues and I were tasked with creating a publication from concept to creation, resulting in a published booklet titled - *Photosynthesis*. This project required applying key principles of technical editing throughout each stage of development, including drafting, revising, formatting, and final production. This analysis highlights the theories of technical editing that we used to ensure clarity, consistency, and accuracy in the final publication.

Audience and Context

The target audience identified for this project were nature enthusiasts and individuals interested in local flora. We paid attention to meeting the needs of the intended audience, as readers actively construct meaning through interaction with a text, rather than passively receiving it (Cunningham et al. 2019), which requires editors to consider audience interpretation as central part of the editing process. The printed publication we designed was created to function as a practical guide to Auburn's plant life while also encouraging creative contributions from the community.

Theory and Application

Cunningham et al. (2019, p.3) state that, "the editor's primary responsibility is to ensure accuracy, readability, organisation, and standard formatting of documents." We were primarily guided by Cunningham et al.'s framework as the project involved identifying the type, levels, and scope of editing required, with particular attention to clarity, flow, and accuracy. In addition to these core editing practices,

principles such as audience analysis, visual communication, layout design, accessibility, and usability - supported through low fidelity testing - was applied throughout the publication process. We ensured that ethical responsibility was also considered; together, these principles informed the team's approach to defining roles, planning, and executing the editing process and making stylistic and structural decisions.

Planning and Collaboration

As collaboration can be understood as rhetorical in nature, process driven, and inherently multimodal (Burnett et al., as cited in Johnson-Eilola & Selber, 2013), our team developed an editorial strategy to ensure efficiency and accuracy throughout the creation of the publication. We utilized collaborative tools, such as [Box.com](https://www.box.com/), which enabled us to work on shared documents simultaneously on documents during both in in-person meetings and remotely. Establishing a clear and structured plan allowed the team to be remain organized and aligned, supporting each stage of the project, including development, curation, and final distribution of the publication.

Additionally, as the editor's primary responsibility involves ensuring accuracy, readability, organisation, and consistent formatting (Cunningham et al. 2019, p.3), my role focused on substantive editing and copyediting, to support the overall quality of publication.

Design and Layout

Finally, design and layout of the publication was especially important in how we presented information to ensure that the content was clearly understood by our audience. An efficient and effective layout improves readability though the use of consistent typography, spacing, and visual hierarchy. We ensured that the formatting followed the established style guide and prioritized practical design choices that enhanced usability. For example, we included an interactive map and high-quality photographs to help readers identify and locate the plants featured in the publication.

References

Donlad H. Cunningham, E. A. (2019). *Technical Editing: An Introduction to Editing in the Workplace*. Oxford University Press.

Johndan Johnson-Eilola, S. A. (2013). *Solving Problems in Technical Communication*. University of Chicago Press.